THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER ONE

“SUIT UP”

September 12 – September 30, 2006
Los Angeles, California

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

FADE IN:

INT. RALEIGH STUDIOS - STAGE 4 - HOLLYWOOD - DAY

SUPER: TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 12, 2006 - 10:31 A.M. PDT

A bare soundstage. One camera, one boom, a folding table, and a cheap leather couch standing in for a billionaire's living room. A strip of gaffer tape on the floor reads "TONY - MARK 1."

JON FAVREAU (39), baseball cap backward, sits beside the monitor with a script that has been rewritten so many times the margins are just arrows. Next to him, arms folded, is AVI ARAD (58), Marvel Studios' chairman, a man who has watched a hundred actors fail at this exact moment.

KEVIN FEIGE (33), president of production, in his trademark cap, stands behind them clutching a tattered copy of TALES OF SUSPENSE #39 in a plastic sleeve, as if it were a rosary.

A READER, a bored actress named DANA (30s), sits on the couch holding sides.

FAVREAU
Okay. Bring him in.

The stage door opens. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (24) walks in wearing a charcoal suit that costs more than the camera, no tie, a smile that has been on lunchboxes since 1995. He sees Feige's comic and stops dead.

MARC-ANTHONY
Is that a first printing? Kevin. Kevin. You brought the Bible to church.

FEIGE
(protective)
It doesn't leave the sleeve.

MARC-ANTHONY
Neither do I, usually. My mom has me laminated.

Dana snorts despite herself. Arad does not.

ARAD
Mr. Bullock. You understand this is a screen test, not a press junket.

MARC-ANTHONY
(sitting, instantly still)
Yes, sir. I'm very grateful to be in the room.

Favreau leans into the monitor. Something has changed. The kid is gone. A grown man is sitting there, bored and brilliant and dangerous.

FAVREAU
Whenever you're ready. From "You build weapons."

DANA (AS REPORTER)
You build weapons, Mr. Stark. Kids in villages you'll never visit are dying under your name.

Marc-Anthony looks at her for a long beat. The script says Tony laughs here. He doesn't.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
You know what my father told me when I was six? He said, "Anthony, peace means having a bigger stick than the other guy." I believed him for eighteen years.

(beat)
I'm starting to think he just liked sticks.

Favreau's pen stops moving. That line isn't in the script.

DANA (AS REPORTER)
That's a cute answer.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
I'm a cute guy. It's a curse. Ask me the real question.

DANA (AS REPORTER)
(off script, rattled)
...Can you sleep at night?

A long pause. Marc-Anthony's eyes go somewhere far away, somewhere Kid Mayor never went.

MARC-ANTHONY (AS TONY)
I've got a hundred and twelve rooms and I sleep in the one closest to the garage. Draw your own conclusions.

Silence. The boom operator forgets to breathe. Favreau slowly takes off his cap.

FAVREAU
...Cut.

Marc-Anthony blinks, and the kid comes back like a light switch.

MARC-ANTHONY
Sorry about the stick thing. It just came out. I can do it as written. I can also do it as a musical.

FAVREAU
(quietly, to Feige)
That's the guy.

ARAD
(under his breath)
That's the guy from KID MAYOR.

FEIGE
That's the guy from KID MAYOR who just did "Demon in a Bottle" with his eyes. Avi, you saw it.

Arad watches the monitor playback. Marc-Anthony's face on the screen, still, haunted. He says nothing. Which, for Avi Arad, is a speech.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - CONFERENCE ROOM - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 21, 2006 - 2:15 P.M. PDT

A modest conference room on the second floor of a building whose ground floor is a Mercedes-Benz dealership. Through the floor, faintly, a salesman's voice: "...and the heated seats come standard..."

A whiteboard reads: "IRON MAN - TONY - DECISION BY 9/27." Under it, three names. Two have been erased. The remaining one: "BULLOCK."

Around the table: ARAD, FEIGE, FAVREAU, and LENORA HAYES (41), Marvel's VP of Legal and Business Affairs, sharp, unsentimental, with three BlackBerrys lined up like loaded weapons.

LENORA
I'll say what Merrill Lynch is going to say, so you hear it from me first. We borrowed five hundred and twenty-five million dollars and put up Captain America and the Avengers as collateral. If IRON MAN flops, the bank owns Steve Rogers. And we're about to hand the movie to a kid whose most famous line is "It's not illegal if nobody wrote it down."

FAVREAU
That line is literally Tony Stark's entire philosophy.

LENORA
That line is on a Donohue Channel lunchbox, Jon.

ARAD
She's right about the image. Every parent in America has a picture of that boy on the refrigerator. You want them to watch him drink scotch and build missiles?

FAVREAU
I want them to watch him grow up. That's the whole movie, Avi. A man-child who has to become a man. Who better than an actual child star who actually has to become a man in front of everybody?

LENORA
And the second problem. His grandfather is Victor Donohue. His mother runs Donohue Entertainment. We're a Paramount-distributed independent and we'd be casting the heir to the biggest studio on Earth. The trades will say Natasha Bullock bought her son a superhero.

FEIGE
Except Natasha didn't call us. Not once. Do you know who did call? Desmond Smilley. Four times. About his son Julian.

ARAD
(grimacing)
Five. He called my home on Sunday.

FAVREAU
Julian Smilley read the cave scene like he was selling cologne.

LENORA
Julian Smilley doesn't come with an antitrust story.

Feige stands. He walks to the whiteboard, picks up a marker, and writes in big block letters: "FAITHFUL."

FEIGE
Can I say something that's going to sound crazy?

ARAD
You usually do.

FEIGE
Every Marvel movie anyone else has made, the studio decided it knew better than the comics. They changed the costumes. They changed the powers. They made Daredevil's world smaller, made the Fantastic Four a sitcom, made ELEKTRA. And the fans, the people who've been reading these books for forty years, they could smell it. We are not Fox. We are not Sony. We are the people who own the comics. So I think we announce Tony Stark, and in the same breath, we make them a promise.

LENORA
A promise.

FEIGE
Every Marvel Studios film will be faithful to the source material. The stories, the characters, the history. And every character gets their full power from the comics. If Thor can move planets in the books, Thor moves planets. If the Hulk gets stronger the angrier he gets, there is no ceiling. Nobody gets watered down. Nobody gets... what do the kids call it on the boards?

FAVREAU
Nerfed.

FEIGE
Nobody gets nerfed.

LENORA
You want to put a promise in writing that the visual effects budget can't keep.

FEIGE
I want to put a promise in writing that our writers have to rise to. Lenora, the fans ARE the collateral. They're the only thing standing between us and that bank.

Beat. Downstairs, muffled: "...and that's the AMG package." Arad stares at the word FAITHFUL for a long moment.

ARAD
And the boy? How does a Black kid from the Donohue Channel square with "faithful"? You know what the message boards will say.

FEIGE
Faithful to who Tony Stark IS. Genius. Billionaire. A man who builds a suit in a cave out of scraps because he's too stubborn to die. That's the character. Bullock walked in and was that man for ninety seconds. I've watched that tape forty times.

FAVREAU
Forty-one. I saw you in the edit bay at midnight.

Arad looks at Lenora. Lenora looks at her BlackBerrys. One buzzes. She reads it, and something close to a smile appears.

LENORA
That's his mother's office. Natasha Bullock wants to discuss terms on Monday.

(beat)
Apparently she heard about the screen test from her son, not from us. He told her he'd do it for free.

ARAD
(finally)
...Nobody does anything for free in this town.

FAVREAU
Then he's definitely not from this town.

CUT TO:

EXT. SMILLEY ESTATE - VIEW PARK, LOS ANGELES - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 23, 2006 - 11:04 A.M. PDT

A stately 1962 Mid-Century home on a hill, with manicured hedges and a brass plaque by the door: "WE DO NOT PLAY THE FOOL."

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

A portrait of ZEKE SMILLEY watches over the room. JULIAN SMILLEY (29), handsome enough to sell anything, paces in front of the fireplace reading IRON MAN sides aloud, a little too smoothly.

JULIAN
"I'm a cute guy. It's a curse."

(to himself, frowning)
Who wrote that? That's not even in my sides.

On the couch, SIMONE SMILLEY (27), oversized sunglasses indoors, scrolls a Sidekick phone, bored.

SIMONE
It's not in your sides because the other guy made it up, and now Hollywood is quoting it at lunch. Welcome to the internet, big brother.

DESMOND SMILLEY (48), immaculate in a cream cardigan, a face that sold out the Apollo in 1984, enters on his cordless phone. CELESTE SMILLEY (46) follows him, flawless, holding a coffee nobody is allowed to see her drink.

DESMOND
(into phone, smooth as silk)
No, I understand, Barry. I understand completely. You tell Avi that Julian is available to come back in on Monday, Tuesday, whenever...

(his face tightens)
...Say that again.

Everyone in the room watches Desmond's jaw harden, one muscle at a time.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
The Bullock boy. Natasha's boy.

(beat)
No. No, I heard you.

He hangs up. Very gently. Too gently.

CELESTE
Desmond.

DESMOND
They're "leaning another direction."

JULIAN
Which direction?

SIMONE
(not looking up)
West. Toward Bel Air.

DESMOND
(quiet, deadly)
Simone.

SIMONE
What? I'm just saying what everybody in this room already knows. Marc-Anthony Bullock had the best screen test since the Bible. Kenny from Barry's office told Rochelle, Rochelle told my trainer...

CELESTE
Your trainer is not a news service.

SIMONE
My trainer is the most reliable news service in Los Angeles. She's never once been wrong about who's getting divorced.

Julian sinks into a chair. The sides slip from his fingers.

JULIAN
It was mine, Dad. I could feel it.

DESMOND
(kneeling to him, fierce)
Listen to me. That family took your great-grandfather's money. They took your grandfather's company. Robert Bullock took my name and made it a punchline in PREMIERE magazine. They do not get to take your future, too. Do you hear me? This is not over.

In the archway to the kitchen, unseen, ESTHER SMILLEY (24) holds a glass of lemonade. She has heard every word. Her face gives away nothing. America's sweetheart has had a lot of practice.

She slips back into the kitchen, takes out her pink Motorola RAZR, and types with her thumb, hiding the screen against the refrigerator.

TEXT MESSAGE - ESTHER TO "MAYOR" (saved under his old character name)

SAT 9/23/06 11:09 AM

heard a rumor about u. a big metal one. dont tell me if its true. ok tell me. no dont. ok tell me

She hits send, deletes the message from her outbox, and puts on her famous smile as Celeste walks in.

CELESTE
Who are you texting, sweetheart?

ESTHER
Pastor Williams. About the youth choir.

CELESTE
(satisfied)
Good girl.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT - NATASHA BULLOCK'S OFFICE - BURBANK - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 25, 2006 - 4:40 P.M. PDT

The top floor of the Donohue executive tower. Floor-to-ceiling windows look across the studio lot: the old Mickey Mouse water tower, the animation building, ABC trucks lined up like soldiers.

NATASHA BULLOCK (45) sits behind a desk that was once Gus Donohue's, on speakerphone, pacing like a panther in a Chanel suit. Marc-Anthony is sprawled on her couch eating sunflower seeds, completely at ease. ROBERT BULLOCK (47) leans in the doorway with a director's patience and a director's sunglasses on his head.

LENORA (V.O.)
(over speaker)
...five hundred thousand dollars against back end. That's the offer, Natasha. It's an untested property and a first-time superhero lead.

NATASHA
Lenora, my son's last four films have grossed more than Marvel's entire studio is worth. You don't offer a Donohue scale. You don't offer a Donohue anything. You ask permission to stand near one.

MARC-ANTHONY
(mouth full)
Mom.

NATASHA
(hand up, not looking)
Not now, baby.

LENORA (V.O.)
I understand your position, and respectfully, I have a bank that owns Captain America if this goes wrong...

MARC-ANTHONY
(louder, sitting up)
Lenora? Hi. It's Marc. I'll take it.

Natasha whirls on him. If looks could kill, the couch would be on fire.

LENORA (V.O.)
(startled)
...I'm sorry?

MARC-ANTHONY
The five hundred. I'll take it. Put the back end on whatever helps you sleep. Honestly, keep the five hundred and give it to the crew craft services budget. Get the good bagels. Not the ones with raisins pretending to be chocolate chips.

NATASHA
(to the phone)
Lenora, I'll call you back.

She hangs up. Silence. Robert takes his sunglasses off his head, a man settling in for a show.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
Do you have any idea what you just did?

MARC-ANTHONY
I got the part, Mom.

NATASHA
You gave away leverage. In this family we do not give away leverage. Your great-grandfather lost a cartoon rabbit because he trusted a man with a contract. Your grandfather built an empire because he never trusted anyone with anything.

MARC-ANTHONY
(gently)
And Granddad hasn't had a friend over for dinner since 1966.

That lands. Natasha stops pacing. Robert winces in sympathy.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
I don't need their money. I have more money than God's accountant. I need Jon Favreau to look at me the way he looked at me last Tuesday. Like I was a man. Do you know how long I've waited for somebody to look at me like that?

NATASHA
(softer)
People look at you like that every day.

MARC-ANTHONY
People look at me like I'm twelve and running for mayor.

Natasha looks at her son, really looks. Robert crosses the room and puts a hand on her shoulder.

ROBERT
Tasha. Let him have this one. The kid's right. You can't negotiate somebody into being taken seriously.

NATASHA
(a long breath)
...Five hundred thousand. Full back end. And Marvel announces it on THEIR schedule, not ours. Nobody on this lot says a word. No Donohue press release. No Donohue anything. If he's doing this, the world finds out he earned it.

MARC-ANTHONY
(grinning)
And the bagels?

NATASHA
I'll buy the crew the bagels myself.

CUT TO:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - LOS FELIZ - NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 27, 2006 - 9:47 P.M. PDT

A beautiful but lived-in hillside home. Framed on the wall: the first KID MAYOR script, a Royce Goodwell animation cel signed by the whole SIMPSONS cast, and a photo of a ten-year-old Marc in Mouseketeer ears.

At the kitchen island, GRACE BULLOCK (12) is doing pre-algebra homework while harmonizing badly to Beyonce's "Irreplaceable" on her iPod. Marc-Anthony makes her a grilled cheese, cutting off the crusts as instructed.

GRACE
If you cut it diagonally, I'll tell Mom you let me watch LOST.

MARC-ANTHONY
You're twelve. Your blackmail should be cuter.

His flip phone buzzes on the counter. The screen says: "FAVREAU - CELL." He freezes. Grace sees it. She freezes too.

GRACE
(whispering)
Is that...

MARC-ANTHONY
(whispering)
Don't. Don't jinx it. Don't breathe near it.

He flips it open.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
Hello, this is Marc.

FAVREAU (V.O.)
Marc. Jon. You got a minute?

MARC-ANTHONY
I've got a lifetime, Jon.

FAVREAU (V.O.)
Good, 'cause you're gonna need it. You're Tony Stark, buddy. Paperwork's done. Avi signed off an hour ago. We announce Friday morning.

Marc-Anthony doesn't say anything. He puts his hand over his mouth. His eyes fill. Grace grabs his arm with both hands, vibrating.

FAVREAU (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Marc? You there?

MARC-ANTHONY
(voice cracking)
Yeah. Yeah, I'm here. I just... Jon, thank you. I'm gonna make you look like a genius.

FAVREAU (V.O.)
I already look like a genius. Now you gotta make me look RIGHT. And Marc? Kevin wanted me to tell you something. The movie's gonna be faithful. Real Tony. The real stuff. No shortcuts. You'll hear more Friday.

MARC-ANTHONY
The real Tony. Got it. Real stuff.

Click. He closes the phone. Turns to Grace. Long beat.

GRACE
(barely holding it in)
Say it.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm Iron Man.

Grace SCREAMS so loudly a dog three houses down starts barking. She leaps onto the island and does a dance that will never, ever be spoken of again. Marc-Anthony laughs and cries at the same time.

GRACE
YOU'RE IRON MAN! MY BROTHER IS A METAL BILLIONAIRE!

MARC-ANTHONY
I was already a billionaire!

GRACE
NOW YOU'RE A METAL ONE!

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. AMOND'S APARTMENT - NORTH HOLLYWOOD - SAME TIME

A small one-bedroom. The rent notice on the fridge is circled in red. AMOND BAKER (24) eats cereal out of a mixing bowl, watching a rerun of ALL THAT where a twelve-year-old Marc does his "Professor Know-It-All" sketch. His phone rings. MARC.

AMOND
(answering, mouth full)
If you're calling to tell me you're on TV, I know, I'm watching you right now. You had a lisp in '95.

INTERCUT - PHONE CONVERSATION:

Marc-Anthony, on his back porch, the city glittering below. Grace is still screaming somewhere inside.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mond. I got it.

Amond stops chewing.

AMOND
Got what?

MARC-ANTHONY
The suit.

Amond sets the bowl down very carefully, like it's a bomb.

AMOND
Shut up. Shut your entire face up. You're Iron Man? YOU'RE IRON MAN?

MARC-ANTHONY
Friday. It's secret till Friday. You can't tell anybody.

AMOND
Who am I gonna tell? My landlord? He thinks I'm a "former kid actor slash current debtor."

(beat, emotional)
Bro. Bro. I'm so proud of you. You know that?

MARC-ANTHONY
Listen to me. They're doing the Hulk next. At Marvel. A new one. Not the Ang Lee one. They need a Bruce Banner.

AMOND
(laughing it off)
Man, they're not gonna let the funny best friend play Bruce Banner.

MARC-ANTHONY
They just let the Kid Mayor play Tony Stark. The rules are changing, Mond. I need you to be in the room when they do.

Amond looks at his TV, at twelve-year-old Marc, at the circled rent notice. Something in him decides.

AMOND
...Okay. Okay. Text me the casting director's name.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - ESTHER'S BEDROOM - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 27, 2006 - 10:22 P.M. PDT

Pink walls she outgrew at fourteen. A Bible on the nightstand next to a hidden paperback of JANE EYRE. Esther is in bed when her RAZR buzzes under her pillow.

TEXT MESSAGE - "MAYOR" TO ESTHER

WED 9/27/06 10:22 PM

its true. dont tell ur dad. actually definitely dont tell ur dad. i am iron. i am man. i am iron man

Esther covers her mouth to keep from laughing out loud. She types.

TEXT MESSAGE - ESTHER TO "MAYOR"

WED 9/27/06 10:24 PM

OMG!!!! im so happy i could scream but i cant scream bc my moms room is next door. proud of u. u deserve it more than anyone. dont let it make u weird

TEXT MESSAGE - "MAYOR" TO ESTHER

WED 9/27/06 10:25 PM

too late. was born weird. night esther

She deletes the whole thread. Lies back. Stares at the ceiling, smiling in a way nobody in her family has seen in years.

CUT TO:

INT. VARIETY.COM - HOMEPAGE - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 28, 2006 - 6:12 P.M. PDT

VARIETY.COM - BREAKING - THU SEPT 28, 2006, 6:12 PM PT

BULLOCK SUITS UP FOR MARVEL'S 'IRON MAN'

Former Donohue Channel star, Simpsons voice and Donohue heir beats out a crowded field for the Tony Stark role; studio to formalize Friday

Marvel Studios has chosen Marc-Anthony Bullock (KID MAYOR, THE SUBSTITUTE PRINCIPAL) to play billionaire industrialist Tony Stark in IRON MAN, the first film the company will finance itself through its $525 million deal with Merrill Lynch. Jon Favreau directs for a May 2, 2008 release through Paramount.

The choice is a gamble. Bullock, 24, is among the most recognizable young performers in America but has never led a film outside the family arena. He is also the grandson of Donohue Entertainment chairman Victor Donohue and the son of CEO Natasha Donohue Bullock. Sources say the Donohue company played no role in the deal...

INT. SUPERHERO HYPE FORUMS - "IRON MAN" SUBFORUM - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 28, 2006 - 6:31 P.M. PDT

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "VARIETY: MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK IS TONY STARK" (Page 1 of 47)

ShellHead1963 (Posted 6:31 PM)
KID MAYOR?????? KID. MAYOR. Tony Stark is a 40-something alcoholic weapons dealer and they cast the kid from the Donohue Channel. I'm done. Marvel is done.

StarkRaving (Posted 6:34 PM)
Have you seen The Substitute Principal? Dude has range. And his Simpsons guy Royce Goodwell is literally Tony Stark if Tony was nice. Calm down.

Repulsor_Ray (Posted 6:36 PM)
Wait, his grandpa OWNS Donohue Entertainment? This is the most nepotism thing that has ever nepotismed.

NoNerfsPlz (Posted 6:39 PM)
Donohue doesn't even own Marvel. It's Paramount. Use your brain.

ShellHead1963 (Posted 6:41 PM)
ok but also... Tony Stark isn't Black. Just saying. I'm not trying to be that guy.

WarMachineRox (Posted 6:44 PM)
You are being that guy. Ultimate Nick Fury has been Black since 2002 and the whole internet wants Sam Jackson. Rhodey has been in the armor. Tony is about genius and ego and a suit, not skin. The suit is the skin, man.

ElektraWasAMistake (Posted 6:47 PM)
All I care about: will they do it RIGHT? Stop making Marvel movies that are embarrassed to be Marvel movies. Fantastic Four had Doom as a CEO. A CEO.

Mjolnir_Worthy (Posted 6:52 PM)
Rumor on AICN is Marvel has a "big announcement" tomorrow besides casting. Something about fidelity to the comics.

ShellHead1963 (Posted 6:55 PM)
I'll believe it when I see it.

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY - THU SEPT 28, 2006, 7:05 PM PT

Marvel Picks The Donohue Heir For 'Iron Man' - And Natasha Didn't Lift A Finger?

My sources tell me the chatter in Burbank is that Natasha Bullock was furious her son negotiated his own deal - for scale. Scale! The richest 24-year-old in Hollywood is working for Marvel at the same rate a supporting player gets on a cable movie. Meanwhile, the View Park camp is livid. Desmond Smilley reportedly campaigned hard for son Julian. Expect fireworks at the Founders' Brunch next year...

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE - MORNING ROOM - BEL AIR - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 - 6:00 A.M. PDT

Morning light floods a breakfast room larger than most houses. A butler sets down coffee. At the head of the table, VICTOR DONOHUE (70), silver-haired and still built like the chorus dancer he was in 1956, reads the print edition of DAILY VARIETY with reading glasses on the end of his nose. JOAN DONOHUE (68), elegant in a silk robe, butters toast with surgical precision.

Across from them, ELXA BULLOCK (26) is curled in a chair with her laptop open to the Marvel website, refreshing it every four seconds.

ELXA
Six o'clock. Six o'clock. Press release, press release...

(refresh)
THERE IT IS!

MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT, INC. - PRESS RELEASE - FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006, 6:00 AM PT

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK TO STAR AS TONY STARK IN MARVEL STUDIOS' "IRON MAN"

Marvel Studios Pledges Every Film Will Be Faithful to the Comics: "Nobody Gets Watered Down"

LOS ANGELES - Marvel Studios today announced that Marc-Anthony Bullock will star as billionaire inventor Tony Stark in IRON MAN, directed by Jon Favreau and slated for release May 2, 2008 through Paramount Pictures.

The studio also announced a founding creative commitment for all Marvel Studios productions: every film will be faithful to the stories, characters and history of Marvel's comics, and every character will be portrayed with their full powers and abilities as established in the source material.

"For forty-five years, Marvel readers have trusted us with these characters," said Kevin Feige, President of Production. "Now we're asking moviegoers to trust us. The way to earn that trust is simple: give them the real thing. The real Tony Stark. The real stories. Full power, every hero, every villain. Nobody gets watered down."

"Marc-Anthony gave us the most exciting audition I have ever seen," said Favreau. "He is Tony Stark: brilliant, funny, reckless, and fighting his way toward becoming a better man."

"Tony Stark was always the guy who had everything and still had to earn his soul," said Stan Lee, Marvel Chairman Emeritus. "I've seen this young man's tape. Excelsior!"

ELXA
"Nobody gets watered down!" Granddad, they put it in the HEADLINE.

VICTOR
(without looking up)
I read it at five-thirty in VARIETY. The print edition, like a civilized man.

JOAN
He's been up since four. He won't admit it.

VICTOR
I was up because the Nikkei was moving.

JOAN
(dry)
The Nikkei doesn't make you cut out articles with my good scissors, Victor.

Victor lowers the paper. Beside his plate: a neatly clipped VARIETY article, folded into his breast pocket. He's caught.

Natasha enters in workout clothes, BlackBerry already in hand, Robert behind her.

NATASHA
CNN wants a comment. ET wants a comment. The LA TIMES wants a comment. Burbank's phones have been ringing since three. And the answer is: no comment. Donohue Entertainment has nothing to do with this. Do we all understand?

ELXA
(quietly, still at the screen)
It's nice. That somebody in this family gets to be hired for being good.

A silence. Natasha glances at her daughter, and for a moment the CEO slips, showing the mother underneath. She knows exactly what Elxa means. Her own 2005 no-family rule hangs over this table.

NATASHA
Elxa...

ELXA
(bright smile, too fast)
I'm happy for him. I really am. I'm going to go call him before the whole planet does.

She leaves. Natasha watches her go. Robert squeezes Natasha's hand.

VICTOR
(to no one in particular)
Marvel. Not ours.

(beat, softer)
Good. Let him have something that isn't ours.

Joan looks at her husband over her coffee. Something old and private passes across her face. She knows a great deal about things that aren't theirs.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - FEIGE'S OFFICE - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 - 9:00 A.M. PDT

Cramped, glorious: longboxes, action figures still in packaging, a poster for the 1966 MARVEL SUPER HEROES cartoon. A conference phone sits in the middle of the desk like a landmine. FEIGE sits in front of it. FAVREAU sprawls in a chair. LENORA stands in the corner with a legal pad, ready to tackle anyone

who says something actionable.

A press call with the trades and the fan press is about to begin. Downstairs, a Mercedes alarm goes off.

OPERATOR (V.O.)
Ladies and gentlemen, the line is open. Our first question comes from THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER.

THR REPORTER (V.O.)
Kevin, the obvious one. You've cast a 24-year-old best known for kids' television as a middle-aged weapons manufacturer. Why?

FEIGE
Because Tony Stark's story is about a man who has been a boy too long and finally has to grow up. Marc-Anthony understands that better than anyone in Hollywood. And for the record, Tony in the comics was a young man when he first built the armor in 1963. Read TALES OF SUSPENSE #39. That's not a talking point. It's on the page.

OPERATOR (V.O.)
Next question, IGN FILMFORCE.

IGN REPORTER (V.O.)
Okay, the pledge. Our readers are going nuts over "every character will be portrayed with their full powers." I have to ask it the way our forums ask it. Is anybody going to get nerfed?

Favreau grins. Feige leans toward the phone.

FEIGE
No. Nobody gets nerfed. Not the heroes, not the villains. If a character can do something in the comics, our job is to figure out how to put it on screen, not how to get out of it. That's the promise.

IGN REPORTER (V.O.)
(audibly delighted)
You understand that I'm going to make that the headline.

FEIGE
I'd be disappointed if you didn't.

Lenora writes on her pad and holds it up to Feige: "DON'T PROMISE PLANETS." He gives her a thumbs up. He is absolutely going to promise planets.

OPERATOR (V.O.)
Next, from SUPERHERO HYPE.

SHH REPORTER (V.O.)
Kevin, a question our message boards are asking, so I'll just ask it directly. How do you square "faithful to the comics" with casting a Black actor as Tony Stark?

A beat. Favreau stops grinning. Feige answers carefully, not defensively.

FEIGE
Faithful to who Tony Stark is. Every story we tell comes from the books. His history, his armor, his genius, his ego, his demons, his friendships, his enemies. Marc-Anthony is going to give the fans the most Tony Stark Tony Stark they've ever seen. I'd ask your readers to judge him on May 2, 2008.

FAVREAU
(leaning in)
And between us, nobody's going to be looking at his skin. He's going to be wearing a lot of red and gold.

OPERATOR (V.O.)
Next, from AIN'T IT COOL NEWS.

AICN CORRESPONDENT (V.O.)
Two questions. One: if this is a "faithful" universe, are we going to see the other Marvel heroes? Two: is it true Natasha Bullock didn't negotiate her son's deal?

FEIGE
One: read the comics. Tony Stark doesn't live alone. That's all I'll say.

LENORA
(stepping toward the phone)
And on the second question, Marvel doesn't discuss the terms of talent agreements.

FAVREAU
(to the phone, cheerful)
But I will say the crew bagels have improved dramatically.

Lenora glares at him. He shrugs, unrepentant.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - THE INTERNET LOSES ITS MIND

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 - 10:00 A.M. TO 12:00 P.M. PDT

AIN'T IT COOL NEWS - TALKBACK: "MARVEL: NOBODY GETS NERFED. BULLOCK IS STARK." (1,284 comments)

Gorgo_The_Mighty (10:02 AM)
"NOBODY GETS NERFED" - KEVIN FEIGE, 2006. Screenshot it. Frame it. If the Hulk can't throw a mountain, we riot.

first! (10:02 AM)
first

Thanos_Was_Right_About_Elektra (10:05 AM)
So Thor moves planets? THOR MOVES PLANETS? Somebody hold me.

Old_Man_Logan_Fan (10:09 AM)
Too bad Fox owns Wolverine. A faithful Wolverine would tear Fox's version in half.

KidMayorStan4Life (10:11 AM)
i grew up with JT Tate and Danny Price and now hes IRON MAN??? this is the best day of my life. "its not illegal if nobody wrote it down" = tony stark's whole personality

Professor_X_Cutioner (10:15 AM)
Every studio says "faithful." Fox said "faithful." Let's see a costume.

Repulsor_Ray (10:22 AM)
ok I take back the nepotism thing. dude did it for scale per Deadline. scale. he could buy Paramount

ShellHead1963 (10:40 AM)
I watched The Substitute Principal last night because of this thread. ...fine. FINE. The kid can act. I'm still worried. But fine.

MYSPACE.COM - MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (OFFICIAL) - BULLETIN - FRI SEPT 29, 2006, 10:30 AM

Subject: so this happened

hi everybody. it's true. i'm going to play tony stark. i've been reading iron man since my grandmother gave me a stack of old comics when i was seven, and i still have tales of suspense #57 under my bed in a bag my mom calls "the ziploc of shame."

to everyone who grew up with J.T. and Danny: thank you. those two raised me as much as you did. i'm not leaving them behind. i'm just bringing them to the garage to help me build something.

to everyone worried: me too. i'm going to work harder than anybody you've ever met.

and to the guy on superherohype who said i'm "too pretty to be a war profiteer": thank you, that's the nicest thing anyone's ever said about me.

- marc

Comments (8,412) | Kudos (21,903)

YOUTUBE.COM - "MARC-ANTHONY IS IRON MAN!!! (REACTION)" - uploaded by xXxComicGirl89xXx - 47,221 views

Description: i literally screamed in my dorm. my roommate thinks im insane. ALSO "NOBODY GETS NERFED" WHAT DOES THAT MEAN FOR THE HULK????? my webcam is bad sorry

FACEBOOK - NEWS FEED (Facebook opened to the public three days ago)

Jasmine T. (Howard University) is ... SCREAMING. KID MAYOR IS IRON MAN. A BLACK TONY STARK. OUR MOM'S GENERATION GOT SHAFT, WE GET STARK.

Mike R. (Ohio State) is ... reading 8 hours of comic book message boards instead of studying for his midterm

INT. MTV NEWS - PHONE INTERVIEW - MARC-ANTHONY'S CAR - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 - 11:15 A.M. PDT

Marc-Anthony sits in his Prius (he owns eleven cars and drives the Prius) in the Marvel parking lot, on speakerphone with an MTV NEWS REPORTER.

MTV REPORTER (V.O.)
So what can you tell us about the movie?

MARC-ANTHONY
(dead serious)
Honestly? It's a period piece. Fourteenth-century Italy. Tony is a blacksmith in Florence who forges a suit of armor to win the heart of a duchess. Jon wanted to go back to Iron Man's roots. Like, literal iron.

MTV REPORTER (V.O.)
(scribbling, uncertain)
...Really?

MARC-ANTHONY
There's a jousting sequence that's nine minutes long. No dialogue. Just horses.

(beat)
I'm kidding. Please don't print that. My lawyer is going to hit me with a shoe.

MTV REPORTER (V.O.)
(laughing)
You almost had me.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'll get you next time. I have two years of press to practice.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 - 12:15 P.M. PDT

Dark wood, trophies, a framed 1984 JET cover of Desmond smiling. On the TV, CNN HEADLINE NEWS' SHOWBIZ TONIGHT promo loops: "DONOHUE HEIR IS IRON MAN - TONIGHT AT 7." On the desk, the VARIETY article, crumpled and smoothed out again, twice.

Desmond sits utterly still. Julian stands at the window. Celeste is in the doorway. Simone sits on the arm of a leather chair, scrolling. Esther stands quietly behind her mother.

SIMONE
(reading off her Sidekick)
Ain't It Cool News is calling him "the best casting since Christopher Reeve." Ooh. Somebody on Superhero Hype made a fan poster. He looks good in red.

CELESTE
Simone, put it away.

JULIAN
(bitter)
Scale. He took scale. Who does that?

SIMONE
Somebody who's richer than God?

DESMOND
(very quiet)
Everyone out. Except Julian.

Celeste ushers the girls out. At the door, Esther looks back at her father. He doesn't look at her. He's looking at the TV, at Marc-Anthony's smiling face.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
Do you know what they're going to do now? They're going to make him a man. That's what this part is. It's the one thing they could never buy him, and Marvel just gave it to him for free. While my son waits by the phone for "a different direction."

JULIAN
Dad, maybe it just wasn't my part.

DESMOND
(rising, intense)
EVERYTHING was your part. It was your great-grandfather's money, it was your grandfather's company, and it was your part.

He picks up the VARIETY article one more time. Reads the line: "Sources say the Donohue company played no role in the deal."

DESMOND (CONT'D)
(a cold laugh)
No role. They never play a role. They just own the theater.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Outside the study, Esther pretends to look at family photos. CORNELIUS SMILLEY (72), the patriarch, walks slowly down the hall with a cane he doesn't really need, his face older than his body. He stops next to her.

CORNELIUS
You know him, don't you? The Bullock boy.

Esther freezes. Her grandfather's eyes are kind and far too sharp.

ESTHER
...A little. From the Kids' Choice Awards. A long time ago.

CORNELIUS
(gently)
Mm-hm. A long time ago.

(beat)
Is he a good boy?

Esther hesitates. Then, for the first time all week, she tells the truth.

ESTHER
He's the best person I've ever met, Granddaddy.

Cornelius nods slowly. He pats her hand and keeps walking. In his breast pocket, unseen, is a faded photograph of two young men on a Harlem rooftop in 1958.

CUT TO:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S HOUSE - LIVING ROOM - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 - 4:20 P.M. PDT

Marc-Anthony is on the floor surrounded by gift baskets: from Paramount, from Marvel, from his SIMPSONS family (a basket shaped like a donut), from Nickelodeon. His landline rings. He answers.

MARC-ANTHONY
Hello?

STAN LEE (V.O.)
(unmistakable)
Is this Tony Stark? This is your father calling. Well, one of them. The one with the mustache.

Marc-Anthony sits bolt upright.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mr. Lee?

STAN LEE (V.O.)
Stan! Everyone calls me Stan, except the IRS. Listen, kiddo, I saw your tape. You know what I loved? You didn't play him like a hero. You played him like a guy who doesn't know he's going to be one. That's the secret, Marc. Tony never thinks he's good enough. That's why he keeps building better suits.

MARC-ANTHONY
(overwhelmed)
Stan, I've been reading your books since I was seven.

STAN LEE (V.O.)
Then you're overqualified! Listen, I have one request. When they do my cameo, make me look handsome.

MARC-ANTHONY
You're already handsome, Stan.

STAN LEE (V.O.)
Oh, I like this kid! Excelsior, Marc!

Click. Marc-Anthony stares at the phone. Then at the ceiling.

MARC-ANTHONY
(whispering)
Stan Lee called me kiddo.

CUT TO:

INT. ROSCOE'S HOUSE OF CHICKEN AND WAFFLES - HOLLYWOOD - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 - 8:30 P.M. PDT

Packed, loud, perfect. The smell of syrup and fried chicken. In a corner booth: Marc-Anthony, Amond, and TAYIA BOYD (24), Marc's co-star from KID MAYOR and DANNY PRICE, laughing so hard she's crying.

TAYIA
You told MTV it was a fourteenth-century jousting movie?

AMOND
Nine minutes of horses! No dialogue!

MARC-ANTHONY
The guy almost wrote it down! He said "Florence" back to me!

A WAITRESS (50s) sets down plates and squints at Marc-Anthony.

WAITRESS
Baby, are you the Kid Mayor?

MARC-ANTHONY
Retired, ma'am. Term limits.

WAITRESS
My grandbabies watched you every day. Now my grandson says you're gonna be a robot.

MARC-ANTHONY
Close enough.

Across the room, a TABLE OF COLLEGE KIDS has been staring. One of them, BRANDON (20), finally stands and shouts:

BRANDON
YO! IRON MAN! PUT IT ON MY TAB!

The whole restaurant laughs. Marc-Anthony stands on his seat, cups his hands.

MARC-ANTHONY
Excuse me! Everybody! Ladies and gentlemen of Roscoe's!

The room quiets.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
Tonight, in honor of the greatest day of my life... everybody's dinner... is on my tab.

The restaurant ERUPTS. Cheers, whistles, a grandmother crying. Brandon films it on a Canon digital camera, holding it sideways.

TAYIA
(pulling him down, laughing)
You're insane!

MARC-ANTHONY
It's not illegal if nobody wrote it down!

The crowd chants back: "IT'S NOT ILLEGAL! IT'S NOT ILLEGAL!" Amond shakes his head, beaming. Then, quieter, Tayia nudges Marc.

TAYIA
Hey. I heard they haven't cast Pepper yet.

MARC-ANTHONY
They haven't.

TAYIA
(playing it cool, failing)
I'm just saying. I've been bossing you around on camera since 1995.

MARC-ANTHONY
(grinning)
Nia Wells, chief of staff. Keisha Monroe, business partner. Pepper Potts, CEO. It's practically a trilogy.

AMOND
And me? What's my trilogy?

MARC-ANTHONY
Funny best friend, funny best friend, the strongest one there is.

Amond laughs, but his eyes go glassy for a second. He looks down at his waffle.

AMOND
(quietly)
From your mouth to God's ears, man.

YOUTUBE.COM - "KID MAYOR (IRON MAN) PAYS FOR ALL OF ROSCOE'S!!!" - uploaded by brandon_LA_405 - Sat Sept 30, 2006 - 312,904 views (and climbing)

Top comment - ChickenWaffleQueen: he really said "put it on my tab" like royce goodwell lmaooo this man is a cartoon in real life

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2006 - 11:58 P.M. PDT

Dark, except for the blue glow of the TV. SHOWBIZ TONIGHT is replaying grainy camcorder footage of Marc-Anthony standing on a Roscoe's booth while the room cheers.

TV HOST (V.O.)
...the 24-year-old heir reportedly picked up the tab for more than eighty diners. Talk about a superhero...

Desmond mutes it. He picks up his cordless phone and dials.

DESMOND
(low)
It's Desmond Smilley. I know what time it is.

(beat)
I want everything on Marc-Anthony Bullock. Every contract. Every ex-girlfriend. Every parking ticket. Every person he's ever been rude to, which I'm sure is a long list. Nobody is that nice. Nobody.

A figure appears in the doorway. CORNELIUS, in a robe, leaning on his cane.

CORNELIUS
Let it go, son.

Desmond covers the receiver. Father and son look at each other across forty years of the same hatred.

DESMOND
Granddaddy Zeke didn't let it go.

CORNELIUS
(sadly)
And look how happy it made him.

Cornelius turns and shuffles away into the dark. Desmond watches him go. Then he uncovers the receiver.

DESMOND
...I'm still here. Start with the girlfriends.

On the muted TV, frozen mid-cheer, Marc-Anthony smiles: the most loved face in America and, as of tonight, the most hated one in View Park.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

SATURDAY MORNING HEADLINES

SUPER: SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 30, 2006

LOS ANGELES TIMES - CALENDAR - SAT SEPT 30, 2006

Marvel Bets the House on a Child Star - and a Promise

The comics company's first self-financed film puts a Donohue heir in the armor, and puts its whole philosophy in writing: "Nobody gets watered down."

USA TODAY - LIFE - SAT SEPT 30, 2006

'Kid Mayor' wins an even bigger election: Bullock is Iron Man

Plus: what Marvel's "full power" pledge could mean for Thor, the Hulk and the movies' long, sad history of disappointing fans.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - ANALYSIS

MARVEL'S FIDELITY PLEDGE: GENIUS MARKETING OR A CHECK THE FX BUDGET CAN'T CASH?

Rival studio executives privately scoff at the idea of putting "full power" heroes on screen. "Wait until they get the bill for Thor," says one.

IGN FILMFORCE - EXCLUSIVE

FEIGE: "NOBODY GETS NERFED"

Marvel's production chief promises full comic-book power levels for every character. "If a character can do something in the comics, our job is to figure out how to put it on screen."

WALL STREET JOURNAL - MARKETS BRIEF

Marvel Entertainment (NYSE: MVL) rises 2.1% as investors cheer "Iron Man" casting buzz; analysts note Bullock's built-in family audience.

JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Week of Oct. 16, 2006)

The Donohue-Smilley Feud Gets a Superhero Chapter

Marc-Anthony Bullock's Iron Man casting leaves one View Park family seeing red - and gold.

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER ONE